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Pataliputra and the Prince

> In the hundredth year after the Nirvana of Tathagata, there was a king called Ashoka (O-shu-kia), who was the great-grandson of Bimbisara-raja. He changed his capital from Rajagriha to Patali (pura), and built an outside rampart to surround the old city. Since then many generations have passed and now there only remain the old foundation walls (*of the city*).[1]

THIS IS HOW THE HISTORY OF THE CREATION OF THE capital city of Pataliputra was described by Xuanzang, the famous Chinese pilgrim who came there in the seventh century CE, more than 800 years after the reign of Ashoka. Of the many Chinese Buddhists who came to India, Xuanzang was the traveller best remembered for the extensiveness of his forays across India, ranging from Kashmir and Punjab to Bihar, Assam, and the peninsula. Wherever he went, he recorded his observations on monasteries, ruined cities, stupas, the myths surrounding them, and a great deal else.

Xuanzang's account of Pataliputra is marked by most of these features. It is part observation and part amalgam of legends. Upon leaving Vaishali and crossing the Ganga, this restless and intrepid pilgrim reached Pataliputra. Located on the holy river's right bank, the city he said was one that had, many centuries earlier, been created there as the new capital of Magadha by Ashoka—no doubt he had been told this or gleaned it from existing legend. Contrary to what Xuanzang believed, however, Pataliputra's establishment as Magadha's capital did not have anything to do with Ashoka, and the Chinese pilgrim may have been confusing Bindusara with Bimbisara—the latter, at any rate, had no relationship of any kind with Ashoka.[2] By the time of Xuanzang's visit, his account suggests, Magadha's realm included towns